Questions to Bring to a Professional About Mom and Medicaid

Fifteen questions, sorted by who can answer them, with room to write what they say.

You'd like to sit down with a professional about Mom someday, and you're not sure what you would even ask. Here are fifteen questions, sorted by the kind of professional each one belongs to. Bring them written down, along with whatever you've noted about Mom's situation, and write the answer under each one.

This guide doesn't answer the questions and doesn't say which matters most. The answers depend on Mom's state and on her situation, and the people below are the ones who can speak to both. Nothing is pressing, so ask when the moment suits.

Your Medicaid planner

Someone who can review how Mom's care and financial picture today compares with the Medicaid rules in her state. These questions depend on rules that vary by state.

1. Which long-term care Medicaid programs does Mom's state have, and which of them would be worth our understanding?

2. Besides money, what would her state look at: where she lives, other nonfinancial requirements, the level of care a person needs?

3. We've been told Mom has too much to qualify. Looking at what we've written down, how would you go about checking that?

4. Which of her accounts and property might her state count, which might it not, and what do you need from us to confirm it?

5. How might her home be treated under her state's rules, and what would you want to know about it?

6. For a retirement account, a life insurance policy or an annuity, what do you need to see?

7. Some things are in two names. What do you need to know about anything Mom owns jointly with someone else?

8. If Mom is married: what should we understand about how her state treats a couple when one spouse needs care, and what would you need to know about her spouse?

9. Here is what has been given away, transferred or retitled in recent years. How does her state look at past gifts and transfers, and what paperwork should we find for each item?

10. Looking at all of it, is there anything that might need attention if Mom ever applied, and which of those would you send to an attorney or a licensed financial professional?

11. Which changes in her health, care needs, finances or marital status should bring us back for another look?

An elder law attorney

Legal questions and legal documents belong to an attorney.

1. There is, or may be, a trust. What would you need to see to tell us what it is?

2. We've talked about a gift, or about changing whose name is on something. What should we understand before anything is done?

A licensed financial professional

Questions about insurance and investment products belong to the licensed professionals who work with them.

1. Mom already owns a retirement account, a life insurance policy or an annuity. Can you explain what each one is and how it works, so we can describe it accurately?

The Medicaid agency in Mom's state

The office that runs Medicaid where she lives.

1. Where can we read about this state's long-term care programs and what each one requires?

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer these questions, rank them, or say what any answer means for Mom. If an answer raises the idea of changing something, write that down as one more question. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You have your questions, and you know which kind of professional each one belongs to. The planning interview gives you something to bring with them: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The Administration for Community Living points families to their state's Medicaid office for information about how to qualify in that state. The questions come from the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's working list for this step, and the grouping by role is ours.

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare information), Medicaid